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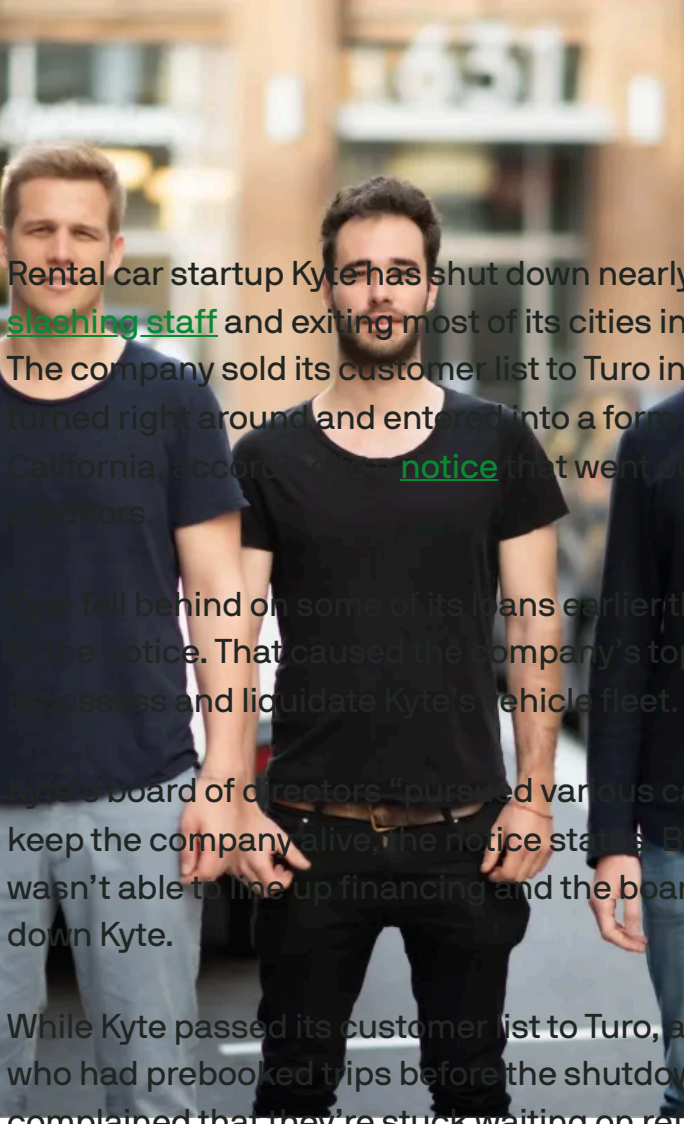
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TRANSPORTATION



Kyte, which billed itself as the 'best competitor to Hertz,' shuts down



Rental car startup Kyte has shut down nearly one year [after slashing staff](#) and exiting most of its cities in the United States. The company sold its customer list to Turo in July and then turned right around and entered into a form of receivership in California, according to a [notice](#) that went out to Kyte creditors.

Kyte fell behind on some of its loans earlier this year, according to the notice. That caused the company's top lender to repossess and liquidate Kyte's vehicle fleet.

Kyte's board of directors "pursued various capital solutions" to keep the company alive, the notice states. But the company wasn't able to line up financing and the board voted to wind down Kyte.

While Kyte passed its customer list to Turo, a number of [users](#) who had prebooked trips before the shutdown have complained that they're stuck waiting on refunds for hundreds of dollars.

IMAGE CREDITS: KYTE

Some who spoke to TechCrunch said they were able to get their credit card companies to perform a charge-back, while others have had no luck. Kyte CEO Nikolaus Volk told TechCrunch in a message that charge-backs may be the quickest way for customers to get that money back.

Founded in 2019, Kyte provided on-demand rental cars that it also delivered directly to customers' homes. It controlled its own fleet of vehicles, making it a bit more like Zipcar and less like the peer-to-peer offerings of players like Turo. Kyte grew to 14 markets and raised more than \$300 million in financing over its lifetime, and started billing itself as the "best competitor to Hertz."

The business started coming apart in 2024, Volk told TechCrunch last year. Kyte was struggling to generate free cash flow in markets like Atlanta, Chicago, Boston, and Washington, D.C. Volk said his team explored selling the business but decided to restructure and focus on reaching profit in the two biggest markets of San Francisco and New York City.

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Kyte’s not the only startup in this sector to run into trouble — especially in the United States. Getaround, another peer-to-peer vehicle rental service, shuttered its U.S. operations [in February of this year](#) to focus on its European business. TrueCar founder Scott Painter [pivoted away from vehicle subscriptions](#) in 2024 after struggling to build up a business called Autonomy.

Topics: [Exclusive](#) [Kyte](#) [Transportation](#) [turo](#) [Zipcar](#)



Sean O'Kane
Sr. Reporter, Transportation |

Sean O’Kane is a reporter who has spent a decade covering the rapidly-evolving business and technology of the transportation industry,...

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Figure's IPO filing marks Mike Cagney's return to public markets

Connie Loizos — 4:23 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Figure Technology, a seven-year-old blockchain-based lending company, on Monday filed for an IPO of its Class A common stock on Nasdaq, saying in its IPO paperwork that its revenue rose 22.4% to \$191 million in the six months ended June 30, and that it reported a profit of \$29 million in the same period, compared with a loss of \$13 million a year earlier.

The filing offers a chance at vindication for Figure co-founder Mike Cagney, who previously built SoFi before leaving the personal finance platform in 2017 following sexual harassment allegations. SoFi went public in 2021 via a special purpose acquisition company (SPAC) merger and has done pretty well as a public company — its stock is up over 200% in the past year, and its revenue rose 44% in the second quarter of 2025.

Since its founding in 2018, Figure has established itself as one of the bigger players in blockchain-based lending, claiming more than 160 partners for its loan origination system and capital marketplace. Figure claims to be the largest non-bank provider of home equity lines of credit.

The company, which Cagney founded with his wife June Ou, uses blockchain technology through its Provenance

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blockchain to speed along approvals for home equity loans, mortgage refinancing, and student and personal loans.

In May, Figure said it was also expanding into cryptocurrency lending, signing a financing agreement with Victory Park Capital for what Figure described as the industry's first securitized pool of crypto-backed loans. That product allows asset owners to borrow against their Bitcoin and Ethereum holdings with loan-to-value ratios up to 75%.

Terms of that deal with Victory Park were not disclosed.

Cagney has a history of ambitious regulatory moves. As TechCrunch [reported](#) in late 2020, during the last days of the first Trump administration, Figure applied for a U.S. national bank charter that would have let it accept uninsured deposits exceeding \$250,000 from accredited investors while avoiding traditional FDIC and Federal Reserve oversight. The approach could have established a template for other fintech and retail companies to obtain non-traditional bank charters and offer lucrative financial products while avoiding such oversight, but Figure withdrew its application last year amid broader fintech industry challenges.



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The company has undergone major leadership and organizational changes in the meantime. In April 2024, Figure appointed Michael Tannenbaum, former COO of Brex, as CEO. Tannenbaum previously worked with Cagney as SoFi's chief revenue officer.

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And in an unusual corporate maneuver, Cagney spun off Figure Markets in early 2024, creating a standalone digital asset exchange for crypto trading, crypto-backed loans, and stablecoins. But just over a year later, in July, Figure reversed course and smooshed the two entities back together.

The company says the strategy positions it to capture a huge and growing opportunity in real-world asset tokenization.

(Real-world asset tokenization involves converting traditional assets like mortgages, real estate, or loans — even art — into digital tokens that can be traded on blockchain networks. Heavyweight financial players like BlackRock and JPMorgan are among those who have recently entered the space.)

It's worth noting that this is not Figure's first attempt at going public. The company previously planned to list via a merger with a SPAC called [Figure Acquisition Corp](#), but the deal got scrapped due to rising interest rates and redemption rates, among other challenges. The blank check company was later delisted from the New York Stock Exchange.

Figure, whose backers include Apollo Global Management and Ribbit Capital, also failed to complete a [planned merger](#) with mortgage lender Homebridge Financial Services in 2022, citing regulatory delays 10 months after the tie-up was announced.

The IPO filing is no surprise to industry observers. For one, Figure — which last raised \$200 million in 2021 at a \$3.2 billion valuation — announced [weeks ago](#) that it had filed a confidential statement for an IPO. Further, the timing aligns with a growing wave of crypto-related companies seeking public listings, encouraged by the wildly successful debut of Circle Internet Group back in June, and the Trump administration's full-bodied support for the cryptocurrency sector and [related legislation](#).

Circle's shares soared more than 500% in their first two weeks on the public market. Crypto exchange Bullish has added to the momentum as its shares [more than doubled](#) on its first day of trading last week.

On Friday, the Winklevoss twins' crypto exchange Gemini filed for an IPO despite reporting a [\\$282.5 million net loss](#) in the first half of 2025.

Goldman Sachs, Jefferies, and BofA Securities are serving as the lead bookrunners for Figure’s IPO. The number of shares to be offered and their price range have not yet been determined.

Topics: [crypto](#) [Figure Technology](#) [Fintech](#) [IPO](#) [Mike Cagney](#)

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Connie Loizos

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Loizos has been reporting on Silicon Valley since the late '90s, when she joined the original Red Herring magazine. Previously the Silicon Valley...

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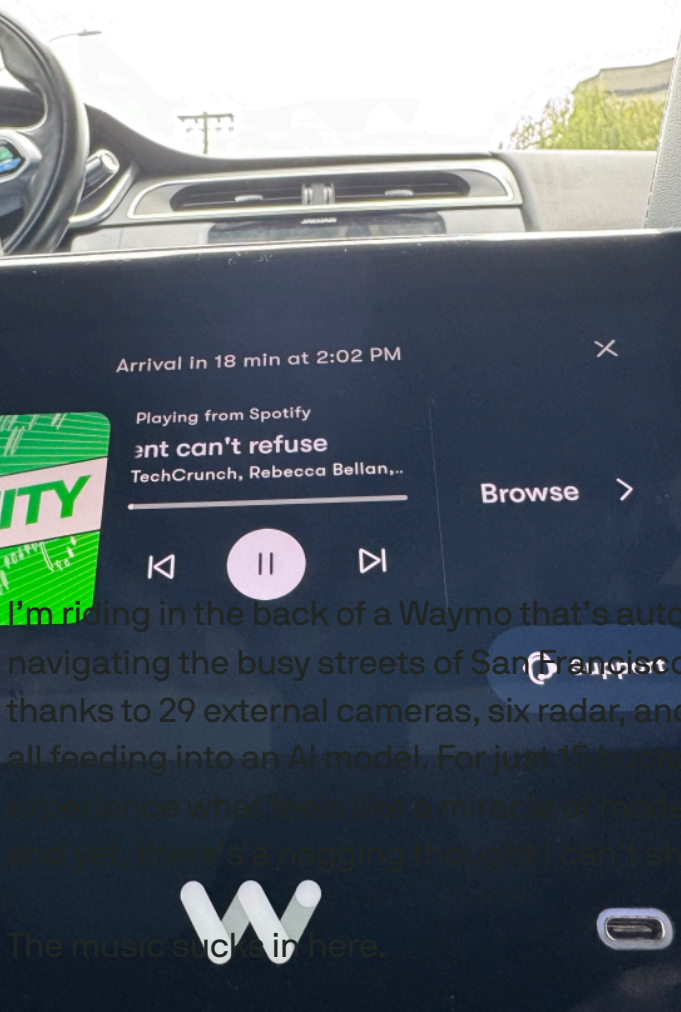
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TRANSPORTATION



Waymo finally has a music experience worthy of its robotaxi

Maxwell Zeff — 1:03 PM PDT · August 13, 2025



I'm riding in the back of a Waymo that's autonomously navigating the busy streets of San Francisco with relative ease thanks to 29 external cameras, six radar, and five lidar sensors all feeding into an AI model. For just 15 bucks, I get to experience what feels like a miracle of modern technology, and yet, there's a nagging thought I can't shake.

The music sucks in here.

Waymo's music-streaming feature has felt like an aged barnacle attached to a futuristic shell. Until this week, passengers were limited to a few music stations that played lo-fi beats, smooth jazz, K-pop, or other genres they may or may not care for. For those who wanted to listen to something more specific, they had to use another app from Waymo's parent company Alphabet.

For iPhone users, that meant downloading the Google Assistant app and configuring it to connect to Spotify. At that point, you had to ask Google Assistant through written or verbal commands to stream certain songs, artists, or playlists on the Waymo. Even if you get to this point — at which you may be halfway to your destination and have listened to approximately three lo-fi beats — the service didn't work reliably.

As I rode along in a robotaxi full of cutting-edge technology, I was puzzled why Waymo had not figured out a simple way to stream music from my phone into the car's speakers — a breakthrough that automakers and audio manufacturers figured out a couple of decades ago.

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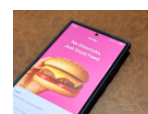
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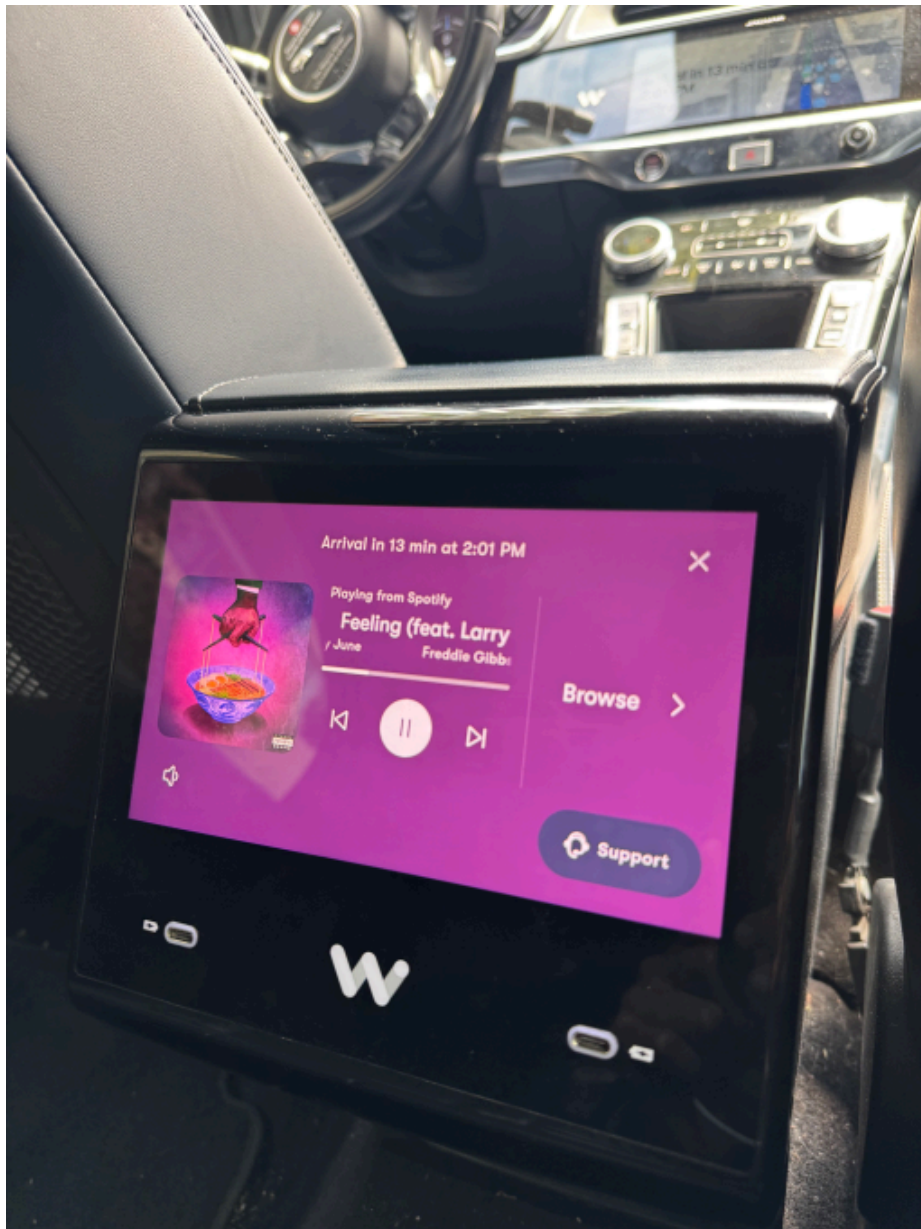


India's Rapido begins testing food delivery to take on Swiggy, Zomato

Jagmeet Singh - Aug 13, 2025

That's why I was pleasantly surprised this week to see that Waymo launched a [Spotify integration](#) allowing users to seamlessly link the music-streaming and robotaxi-hailing services. I immediately connected the services and hailed a Waymo to see how it would work.

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LISTENING TO SPOTIFY IN A WAYMO.

IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL ZEFF

Waymo's Spotify integration is nothing groundbreaking, but it adds to the user experience. It works seamlessly, which is roughly what I would expect when trying to play music on my car's speakers in 2025. But riding around in a Waymo, listening to my own playlist or picking up where I left off on a podcast, the back seat of the robotaxi feels more like my own space — which is increasingly the reason I opt for a Waymo.

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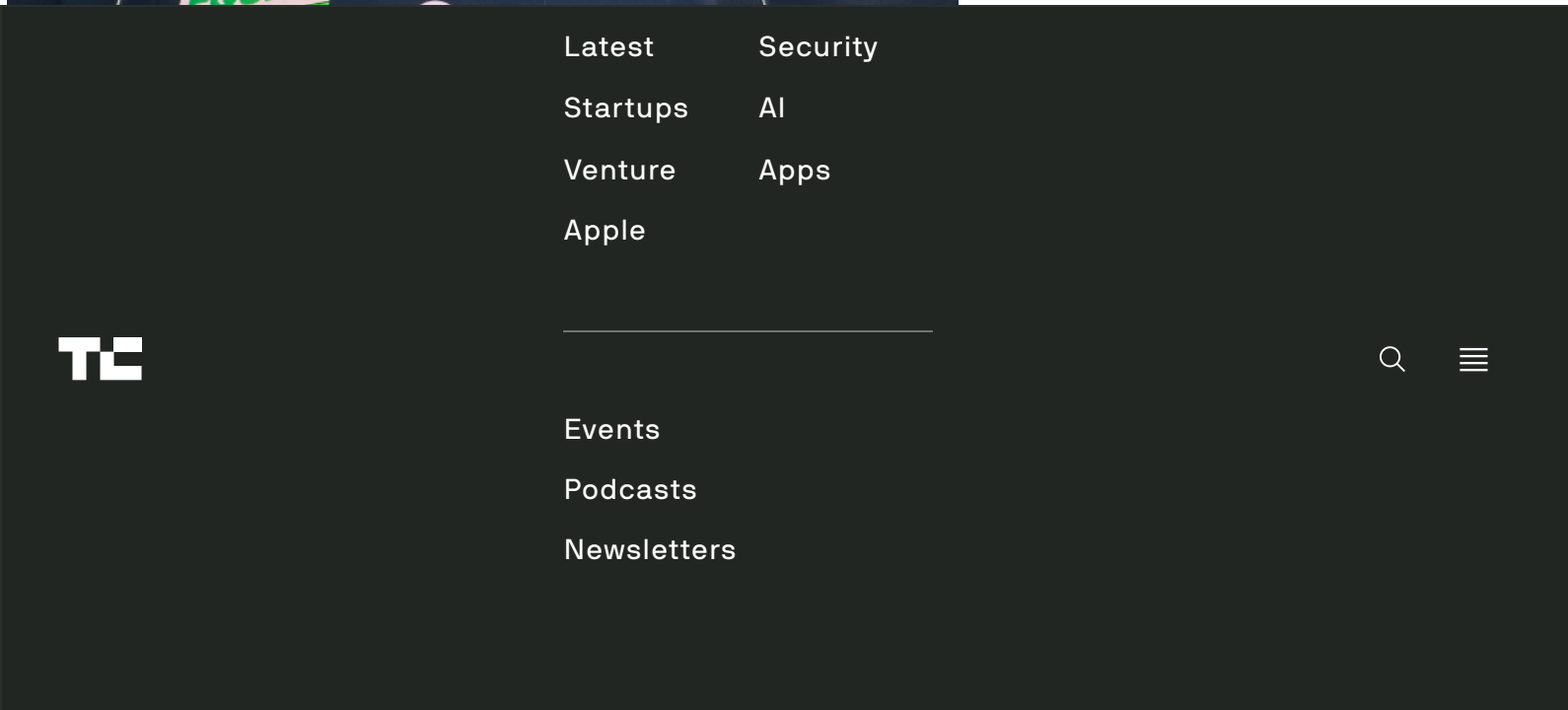
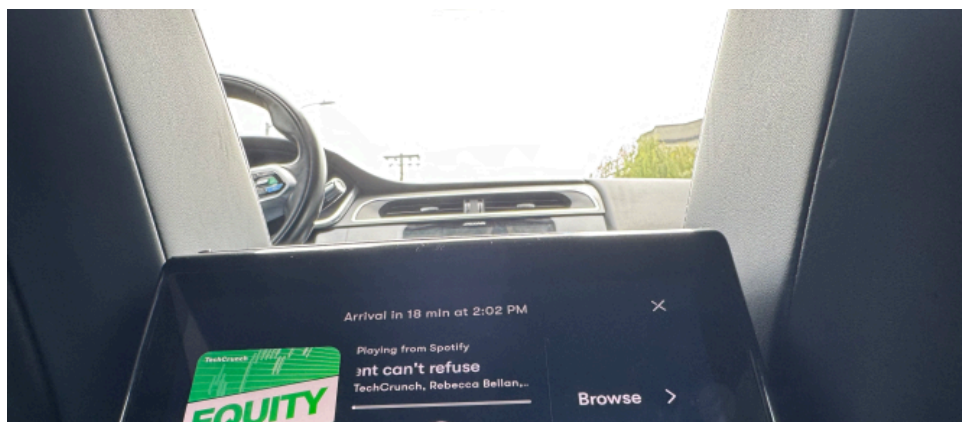
To set it up, open the Waymo app and navigate to the “Music” section, where you will notice a new offering that lets you connect to Spotify. From there, you can press a button and authorize Spotify to connect to Waymo, albeit while giving the robotaxi provider some access to your listening information.

IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL ZEFF
(SCREENSHOT)

IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL ZEFF
(SCREENSHOT)

I'm sure Apple Music users will soon want to stream their music and podcasts in Waymos as well. Waymo spokesperson Chris Bonelli told TechCrunch the company is always exploring new personalization options but did not clarify when the company might add an Apple Music integration.

Once my Waymo and Spotify accounts were linked, I hailed a Waymo like I usually would and got in. On the Waymo’s touchscreen in the back seat, there’s an option to select Spotify. I tapped it, and the podcast I was listening to on my headphones started playing from the exact spot I left off.



podcast and then getting a Waymo that went through a

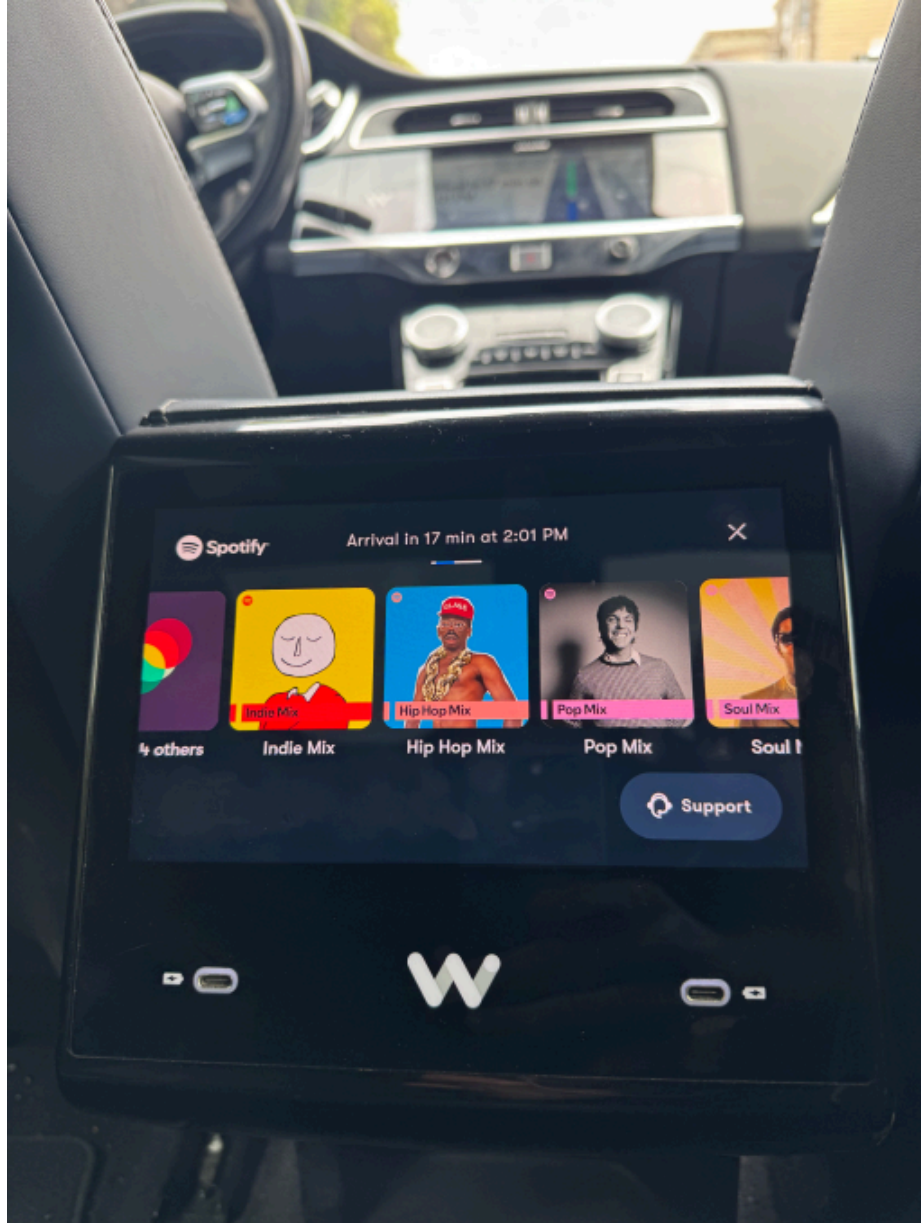
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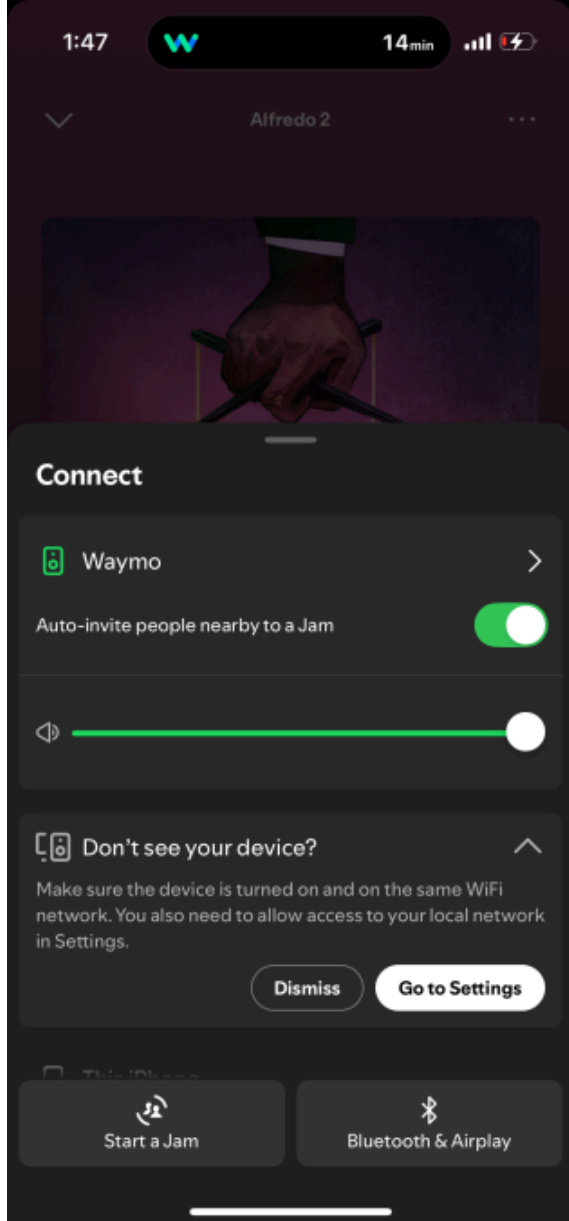
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You can also use the Waymo’s touchscreen to select from a variety of customized playlists that Spotify users will be familiar with, such as your “Daylist” or other mixes. However, this selection doesn’t seem to include albums, audiobooks, or podcasts that you’ve recently listened to.



CHOOSING FROM DIFFERENT SPOTIFY MIXES. IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL ZEFF

Luckily, your Spotify app now controls the music in the Waymo. You can simply select any song or playlist you want from your smartphone and stream it throughout the vehicle like you would using Apple CarPlay or a bluetooth speaker.



CONTROLLING THE WAYMO'S TUNES WITH YOUR PHONE.

IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL ZEFF

In the end, the Spotify integration made my robotaxi feel more personalized; I was even able to tweak the bass, subwoofer, and treble levels in the car's speakers. That personalization may not be the main attraction for first-time users, but it could keep them coming back — and a loyal customer base is exactly what Waymo needs.

Topics: [AI](#) [robotaxi](#) [Spotify](#) [Transportation](#) [Waymo](#)



Maxwell Zeff

Senior AI Reporter | [X](#)

Maxwell Zeff is a senior reporter at TechCrunch specializing in AI. Previously with Gizmodo, Bloomberg, and MSNBC, Zeff has covered th...

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India’s Rapido begins testing food delivery to take on Swiggy, Zomato

Jagmeet Singh — 11:08 AM PDT · August 13, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

Rapido, a popular ride-hailing platform in India, has quietly begun beta testing its food delivery service in Bengaluru, marking its first serious move to challenge market leaders Swiggy and Zomato in one of the world’s fastest-growing delivery markets.

The 10-year-old startup has started testing its food delivery service in three primary localities in the southern city of Bengaluru, namely Byrasandra, Tavarekere, and Madiwala (BTM) Layout, Hosur Sarjapura Road (HSR) Layout, and Koramangala, Rapido co-founder and CEO Aravind Sanka confirmed to TechCrunch.

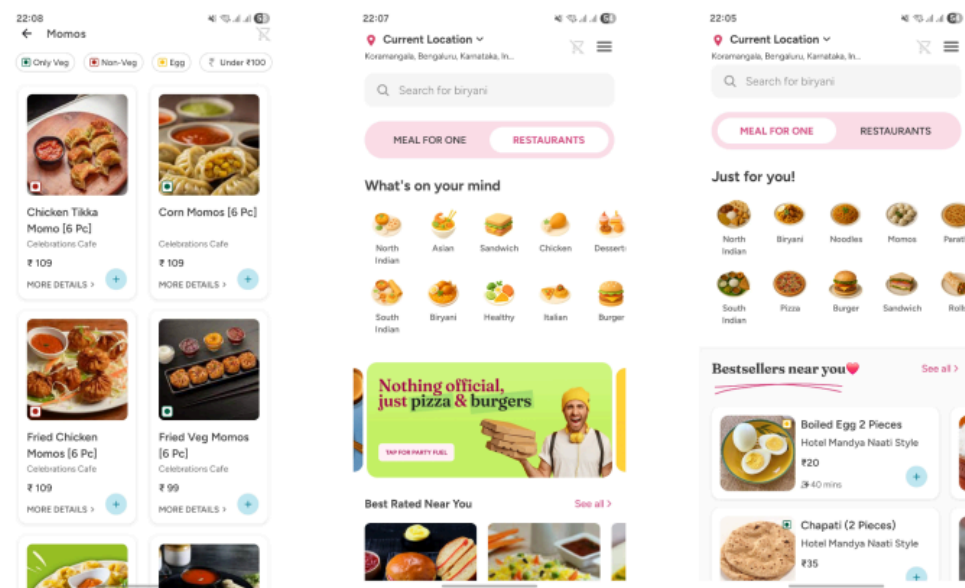
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Rapido created a wholly owned subsidiary Ctrlx Technologies to launch its food delivery service, named Ownly. The subsidiary lists Sanka and Rapido vice president of finance Vivek Krishna as the directors, per the regulatory filings reviewed by TechCrunch.

Sanka said there was no specific reason for setting up the subsidiary. However, it may be a strategic move to avoid potential conflicts of interest with Swiggy, which currently holds a 12% minority stake in the ride-hailing startup.

Swiggy recently [confirmed](#) in a letter to shareholders that it would reevaluate its investment in Rapido, citing a potential conflict of interest “that may arise in the future.”

Meanwhile, Rapido’s Ownly has also [released](#) its Android app on Google Play that offers food from nearby restaurants at around 15% lower prices than those on Swiggy and Zomato.



RAPIDO’S OWNLY FOOD DELIVERY APP.

IMAGE CREDITS:OWNLY

The lower pricing is a result of Rapido’s model of not taking commissions from restaurants, which are up to 30% in the case of other food delivery apps, including Swiggy and Zomato, and instead charging a fixed fee per order. The startup [mentioned its fixed-fee approach](#) in a proposal to restaurants in June.

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Rapido has a fleet of around 10 million vehicles, including 5 to 6 million two-wheelers, across India, a person familiar with the startup's business told TechCrunch recently. The company is using its two-wheeler fleet to deliver food — alongside offering its taxi and courier services.

Rapido will avoid showing restaurants located far from customers to reduce fuel costs and delivery times, and will curate menu items on its app to maximize margins while offering enough discoverability, a Rapido investor told TechCrunch on condition of anonymity.

While handling deliveries for Swiggy, Rapido gained insight into peak hours and high-demand restaurants — the data it would now leverage for its own food delivery service, the investor said.

The agreement with Swiggy does not prevent Rapido from using this data, although it does prohibit the startup from entering into contracts with Zomato or other competitors, the investor added.

Founded in 2015, Rapido began as a bike taxi aggregator before expanding into auto rickshaws, parcel delivery, and third-party logistics. In 2023, it [entered the cab business](#) to take on Uber and local rival Ola. The startup gained traction in this segment with its subscription-based model, positioning it as an alternative to the commission-based approach used by its competitors.

Rapido also [partnered with Taiwanese battery-swapping electric two-wheeler maker Gogoro](#) to deploy its vehicles as bike taxis. Moreover, the recent moves helped the startup boost its valuation and [become a unicorn](#) last year.

India's online food delivery market is [projected to surpass ₹2 trillion](#) (approximately \$23 billion) by 2030, per a report by Bain

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& Company and Swiggy released last year. Zomato currently [leads the market with a 58% share](#), according to brokerage firm Motilal Oswal, while Swiggy [holds the remaining 42%](#), per Bernstein. Uber was also among the early players in the space with Uber Eats, which it [sold to Zomato in early 2020](#).

So far, Rapido has raised \$574 million in 13 rounds, [per](#) Tracxn. It operates in more than 250 cities and handles over 3.5 million rides daily. The startup counts Prosus, WestBridge Capital, Nexus Venture Partners, and Think Investments, among its key investors.

Topics: [Apps](#) [food delivery](#) [India](#) [Rapido](#) [Startups](#) [Swiggy](#)

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Jagmeet Singh

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Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for TechCrunch. He...

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